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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Pritzker calls for boycott, protest

Action would target outlets that helped fuel Kimmel suspension

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker has called for boycotts and protests against broadcast outlets that are tied to Wednesday's decision by the Walt Disney Co. and its ABC network to indefinitely suspend comedian Jimmy Kimmel's nightly talk show, including against WGN's television and radio stations and WLS-Ch. 7 in Chicago.

It was part of a larger call to action by the two-term governor after ABC pulled "Jimmy Kimmel Live!" following Federal Communications Commission Chair Brendan Carr's threats that the agency would take steps against the network over comments Kimmel made about the assassination of conservative activist Charlie Kirk.

Two of the network's largest affiliate groups, Nexstar Media Group Inc., and Sinclair Broadcasting, said they would preempt or suspend airing Kimmel's show on their stations after Carr's warning, which prompted ABC to pull the show off the air indefinitely.

Nexstar acquired WGN-TV and WGN-AM radio from the former Tribune Broadcasting Co. in September 2019. WGN-TV, which is not an ABC affiliate, is among more than 200 owned and partner stations under Nexstar, which also is seeking FCC approval to acquire Tegna's 64 television stations. Additionally, Sinclair, which owns ABC's largest affiliate group, is also seeking merger options that would require FCC approval. ABC 7 is owned and operated by Disney.

Pritzker, appearing Wednesday night on MSNBC's "The Briefing with Jen Psaki," said the threat of FCC action over Kimmel was using the power of government to "intimidate" companies over people who criticize the Trump administration. Kimmel has been

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Veronica Beltran, right, hugs a Warrenville resident in the Menards parking lot in Naperville on Wednesday. Beltran's father, Martin Morales, was arrested by immigration authorities earlier that morning. CAROLYN STEIN/NAPERVILLE SUN

Advocates: Agents targeting day laborers at home stores

Some see heightened patrols as part of Trump administration's 'Operation Midway Blitz'

By Carolyn Stein and Rebecca Johnson
Naperville Sun

As soon as Veronica Beltran heard from her mom that federal immigration agents had detained her father at a Naperville Menards, she rushed from work to the home improvement store.

But by the time she got to the store on Fort Hill Drive, it was already too late. He was gone, she said.

"It's ridiculous, the world that we live in," Beltran told the

Tribune tearfully as she stood in the parking lot with her sister, watching their father's van get towed away. "Harming so many families, separating so many kids from their parents when they should be focusing on getting the criminals, the ones that harm this country, not the ones who work their asses off and pay taxes."

Her father, Martin Morales, a Montgomery resident who owns a wood flooring company, was one of at least three people agents detained at the store Wednesday morning, according to witnesses.

A day later, activists said at a news conference that agents have also begun targeting day laborers in Chicago as part of the Trump administration's "Operation Midway Blitz," calling it an "unwarranted attack."

Miguel Alvelo Rivera, the executive director of Latino Union Chicago, said Thursday he believes about five day laborers were detained in the past two days, including three people at a Home Depot in the Montclare neighborhood. He said activists are still working to learn who the workers are and exactly where

they were taken. Others reported heightened patrols at home improvement stores in Cicero and Berwyn.

"We are still not 100% sure who exactly was taken," he said. "A lot of the calls are coming from other workers who are at those corners letting us know what happened."

He also criticized companies like Home Depot, which he said "benefit from the undervalued and often unpaid labor of our working neighbors" and

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Students leave EPIC Academy, 8255 S. Houston Ave., in Chicago, at the end of the school day on Wednesday. TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGOTRIBUNE

EPIC Academy school to close

Board votes unanimously to shutter at end of academic year as students, staff rally in support

By Kate Perez
Chicago Tribune

While students scanned their IDs and chatted with staff as they entered the hallways of EPIC Academy, in a nearby classroom, the charter school's board of directors sat stoically, faces drawn.

Minutes later, the board voted unanimously to close EPIC at the end of the academic year, citing

low enrollment as a driver of their troubled finances.

While the vote was unanimous, it was not made lightly, board of directors Chair Andrew Annacone said at the meeting Wednesday morning.

"There's not a person in this room who isn't troubled and saddened by this moment," Annacone said. "No one, from families, to staff, to teachers, to students, to CPS (Chicago Public

Schools), wants to see us close, and we wish it were possible to remain open."

Dwindling enrollment numbers since 2020 have severely impacted the school's bottom line, which ties its revenue to each student that attends the school, EPIC Academy Executive Director LeeAndra Khan told the Tribune. When Khan started at the high school in 2020, the total enrollment was 566 students. Five years later, enrollment has plunged 55% to

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Cook County property tax bill delay continues

Board creates \$300M loan fund to help taxing bodies make ends meet

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

It's still unclear when Cook County homeowners and other property owners will receive their property tax bills, top officials told commissioners this week, thanks to lingering defects in a tech upgrade already delayed by several years.

Now the county has launched a \$300 million loan fund to help cities, towns and other taxing bodies that will struggle to make ends meet without those property tax revenues in hand.

The new system was supposed to be ready in April. County leaders committed to officially make the switch off their legacy system — housed on decades-old main-frame computers — to fully adopt Tyler Technology's system in May

in time for the normal bill schedule, with bills due by Aug. 1.

"I want to be transparent with this board," Chief Technology Officer Tom Lynch told commissioners on the Cook County Board's Technology Committee on Wednesday. "We have made a lot of progress, but we're not done either."

Property tax offices cannot generate accurate bills yet, nor could they distribute the money back to taxing bodies after bills are paid, Lynch told commissioners.

In response, the County Board on Thursday directly authorized borrowing \$300 million to fund a local taxing district loan program. The county created a similar fund in 2022 — the last time bills were late — to aid suburban taxing jurisdictions that had a cash crunch and high borrowing costs. The county will be automatically paid back when those property tax revenues do come in.

The need might be higher this

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INSIDE

Vaccine panel OKs new restrictions

A committee Thursday advised the combination shot that protects against chickenpox as well as measles, mumps and rubella should not be given before age 4. **Nation & World**

Sox rebuild still in preconstruction

The White Sox need to go 6-3 over their final nine games to avoid losing 100 for the season, and they face two teams vying for postseason seeding in the Padres and Yankees. **Sports**

